

Obama campaign was a study in fool proof political management. First, the timing. He hit the arena at a time when America was desperate for a saviour-in-chief. Then the style of the campaigner. He was the coolest guy on the stump: elegant, brainy, and with a touch of the prophetic. During the debates, he was less provocative and most reassuring, and always held his elder, honourable opponent in high esteem. There was no grimace of mockery, no gesture of impatience. There was an air of quite authority—and confidence. That face never revealed what was simmering within. He was presidential before he was elected President. The demeanour was consistently statesmanlike. He struck a fine balance between private ambition and public dignity.

Equally forceful was the loyalty, dedication and the cohesiveness of the Obama Army of managers, strategists and the ever-growing legion of young, star-struck volunteers. The Obama

REUTERS/KEITH BEDFORD



MICHELLE OBAMA AND DAUGHTERS SASHA AND MALIA; (RIGHT) GRANDMOTHER SARAH HUSSEIN ONYANGO OBAMA



REUTERS/THOMAS MUKOYA

THERE WOULD HAVE BEEN NO OBAMA THE COMPASSIONATE INTERNATIONALIST WITHOUT THE BACK ALLEYS OF JAKARTA.

Sena operated as if they were the members of a cult. With \$750 million to burn—an all-time record in fundraising—he outspent everyone in the arena, beginning with the primary. (Predictably, being a Democrat, he was the favourite of most American-Indians, that too despite an initial gaffe by his staff last year. A campaign memo from his “opposition research unit” ridiculed Hillary Clinton for the former first lady’s India connection: “Hillary Clinton has taken tens of thousands from companies that outsource jobs to India. Workers who have been laid off in upstate New York might not think

that her recent joke that she could be elected to the Senate seat in Punjab is that funny.” Obama had to apologise.)

Throughout the campaign, he refused to play the race card. His politics was not subordinated to the colour of his skin. His argument about race is much more nuanced. He is not your average angry Black wallowing in victimhood. Earlier this year, speaking at Philadelphia, while breaking himself free from his pastor and spiritual mentor Jeremiah (God Damn America) Wright Jr., he quoted William Faulkner to make himself comprehensible to Blacks and White alike: “The past isn’t

dead and buried. In fact, it isn’t even past.” His generation is trapped in a racial stalemate. “Contrary to the claims of some of my critics, Blacks and Whites, I have never been so naive as to believe that we can get beyond our racial divisions in a single election cycle, or with a single candidacy—particularly a candidacy as imperfect as my own. But I have asserted a firm conviction—a conviction rooted in my faith in God and my faith in the American people—that working together we can move beyond some of our old racial wounds, and that in fact we have no choice if we are to continue on the path